

WhatsApp Cloud API — Pricing, Windows & Subscription Strategy

Complete Business Guide for WA Commerce Platform

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1. Conversation-Based Pricing Model

How Meta Charges

WhatsApp Cloud API charges per **conversation** (a 24-hour messaging session), NOT per message. Once a conversation window opens, all messages of that same category within that 24 hours are free.

Conversation Categories

Category	Who Initiates	India Price (INR)	US Price (USD)	When Used
Service	Customer messages first	FREE (₹0)	FREE (\$0)	Customer inquiries, browsing, ordering
Utility	Business sends template	₹0.30	\$0.005	Order updates, payment confirmations, delivery
Authentication	Business sends OTP template	₹0.25	\$0.004	OTP verification, login codes
Marketing	Business sends promo template	₹0.80	\$0.015	Campaigns, offers, abandoned cart reminders

Key Principle

You pay **ONCE** when a conversation window opens. All subsequent messages of the **SAME** category within that 24-hour window are **FREE**.

2. The 24-Hour Window System

How Windows Open & Close

WINDOW LIFECYCLE:

Message sent/received → Window OPENS → 24 hours pass → Window CLOSES

24 Hours

OPEN (charged once)	All messages FREE (same category)	CLOSED (need new window)
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Service Window (Customer-Initiated)

Opens when: Customer sends ANY message to your business number **Duration:** Exactly 24 hours from when the conversation session was created **Cost:** FREE (₹0) **What you can send:** ANYTHING — free-form text, buttons, lists, images, videos, documents **Resets on new message?** NO — the window does not extend when customer sends more messages

Example:

10:00 AM Mon – Customer sends "Hi"
 → Service window opens (expires 10:00 AM Tue)
 10:05 AM Mon – You reply with catalog (FREE)
 11:00 AM Mon – Customer sends "I want to order"
 → Window does NOT reset (still expires 10:00 AM Tue)
 2:00 PM Mon – You send order confirmation text (FREE)
 5:00 PM Mon – You send payment QR buttons (FREE)
 10:01 AM Tue – Window EXPIRED
 10:02 AM Tue – You send text message → ❌ FAILS (error 131047)

Utility Window (Business-Initiated)

Opens when: You send a UTILITY category template **Duration:** Exactly 24 hours **Cost:** ₹0.30 (charged once when window opens) **What you can send:** Only more UTILITY templates (within same window = free) **Cannot send:** Free-form text, buttons, lists, marketing templates

Example:

2:00 PM Tue – You send "order_shipped" template
 → Utility window opens (₹0.30 charged, expires 2:00 PM Wed)
 4:00 PM Tue – You send "delivery_update" template (FREE – same utility window)
 2:01 PM Wed – Utility window EXPIRED
 2:02 PM Wed – You send "order_delivered" template
 → NEW utility window opens (₹0.30 charged again)

Marketing Window (Business-Initiated)

Opens when: You send a MARKETING category template **Duration:** Exactly 24 hours **Cost:** ₹0.80 (charged once) **What you can send:** Only more MARKETING templates **Cannot send:** Free-form text, utility templates

Authentication Window (Business-Initiated)

Opens when: You send an AUTHENTICATION template (OTP) **Duration:** Exactly 24 hours **Cost:** ₹0.25 (charged once) **What you can send:** Only more AUTH templates **Typical use:** OTP verification, login codes

3. Template Categories & Rules

What Qualifies as Each Category

Utility Templates (₹0.30)

Must reference a **specific, existing transaction** initiated by the customer.

Allowed (Utility)	NOT Allowed (will be rejected)
"Your order #123 shipped"	"Check out new products"
"Payment received for order #456"	"Your exclusive deal awaits"
"Delivery arriving at 5 PM"	"We miss you, come back"

"Your refund processed"	"Flash sale starting now"
"Appointment reminder for tomorrow"	"Book an appointment today"

Marketing Templates (₹0.80)

Promotional content, re-engagement, campaigns.

Allowed (Marketing)	Notes
"20% off this weekend!"	Must include unsubscribe option
"New collection just dropped"	Requires customer opt-in
"Your cart is waiting"	Abandoned cart reminders
"We miss you! Here's a coupon"	Win-back campaigns

Authentication Templates (₹0.25)

OTP and verification codes ONLY.

Allowed (Authentication)	NOT Allowed
"Your code is 123456"	"Your code is 123456. Also check our sale!"
"Verify with code: {{1}}"	Any additional promotional content

Template Submission Rules

- Template names: lowercase, underscores only (e.g., `order_confirmation`)
- Maximum: 250 templates per WABA
- Variables: `{{1}}` , `{{2}}` , etc. — must provide examples during submission
- Buttons: Max 3 quick-reply buttons OR 2 URL/call buttons
- Review time: Auth (instant) → Utility (minutes-hours) → Marketing (hours-days)
- Once approved: CANNOT be edited (must delete and recreate)

4. Window Interactions & Edge Cases

Each Category is Independent

All four window types operate independently. Opening one does NOT affect others.

INDEPENDENT WINDOWS (can all be open simultaneously):

Customer sends "Hi"

→ [Service Window: 24h] FREE

You send utility template

→ [Utility Window: 24h] ₹0.30

You send marketing template

→ [Marketing Window: 24h] ₹0.80

You send auth template

→ [Auth Window: 24h] ₹0.25

Total charge: ₹0.30 + ₹0.80 + ₹0.25 = ₹1.35

(Service is always free)

Critical Edge Cases

Case 1: Template within Service Window

Customer sends "Hi"	→ Service window opens (FREE)
You send "order_confirmation" TEMPLATE	→ ❌ STILL CHARGED ₹0.30 (opens separate utility window)
You send free-form "Order confirmed!"	→ ✅ FREE (uses service window)

Lesson: Within a service window, always use free-form text instead of templates to save money.

Case 2: Customer Replies to Template

You send utility template	→ Utility window opens (₹0.30)
Customer replies "OK"	→ Service window NOW opens (FREE)
You send free-form text	→ ✅ FREE (service window active)
You send buttons with options	→ ✅ FREE (service window active)

Lesson: Once customer replies, you get a free service window. Batch your messages after the reply.

Case 3: Multiple Utility Templates Same Day

2:00 PM – You send "order_shipped"	→ Utility window opens (₹0.30)
3:00 PM – You send "delivery_update"	→ ✅ FREE (same utility window)
4:00 PM – You send "payment_verified"	→ ✅ FREE (same utility window)

Lesson: Batch utility notifications close together to share one utility window.

Case 4: Utility Template After Window Expires

Day 1, 2:00 PM – You send template	→ Utility window opens (₹0.30)
Day 2, 2:01 PM – Window expired	
Day 2, 3:00 PM – You send template	→ NEW utility window (₹0.30 again)

Case 5: Free-form After Template (Without Customer Reply)

You send utility template	→ Utility window opens
You send free-form text immediately	→ ❌ FAILS (no service window)

Lesson: Template windows do NOT allow free-form messages. Only service windows do.

5. Cost Calculation — Real Scenario

Assumptions

- 1,000 active customers
- 2,000 orders per month
- 2 marketing campaigns per month
- Admin receives notifications via personal WhatsApp

Order Lifecycle Cost Breakdown

Single Order Journey:

Event	Timing	Window Status	Method	Cost
Customer orders via chat	Day 1, 10:00 AM	Service window opens	—	₹0
Order confirmation	Day 1, 10:01 AM	Service window active	Free-form text	₹0
Payment confirmation	Day 1, 10:30 AM	Service window active	Free-form + button	₹0

Shipping notification	Day 2, 2:00 PM	Service window EXPIRED	Utility template	₹0.30
Delivery update	Day 2, 6:00 PM	Utility window active	Utility template	₹0
Delivery confirmation	Day 3, 11:00 AM	Utility window EXPIRED	Utility template	₹0.30
Feedback request	Day 3, 11:01 AM	New utility window active	Utility template	₹0
TOTAL PER ORDER				₹0.60

Worst Case (Customer didn't initiate via chat):

Event	Method	Cost
Order confirmation	Utility template	₹0.30
Shipping notification	Utility template (new day)	₹0.30
Delivery confirmation	Utility template (new day)	₹0.30
TOTAL PER ORDER		₹0.90

Monthly Cost Calculation

Customer-Facing Messages:

Scenario	Orders	Cost/Order	Monthly Cost
70% orders via chat (smart sending)	1,400	₹0.60	₹840
30% orders not via chat (all templates)	600	₹0.90	₹540
Subtotal — Order notifications	2,000		₹1,380

Marketing Campaigns:

Campaign Type	Recipients	Cost/Recipient	Monthly Cost
Broadcast campaign (2/month)	1,000 × 2	₹0.80	₹1,600
Abandoned cart reminders	~200	₹0.80	₹160
Subtotal — Marketing			₹1,760

Admin Notifications:

Type	Method	Cost
First notification of the day (template)	~30/month	30 × ₹0.30 = ₹9
Rest of day (free-form after admin replies)	~1,970/month	₹0
Subtotal — Admin		₹9

Authentication:

Type	Sends/month	Cost
Admin OTP	~5	5 × ₹0.25 = ₹1.25
Subtotal — Auth		₹1.25

TOTAL MONTHLY COST SUMMARY

Category	Conversations	Cost (INR)
Service (customer-initiated)	~3,500	₹0 (FREE)
Utility (order/payment/delivery)	~3,600	₹1,389
Marketing (campaigns)	~2,200	₹1,760
Authentication (OTP)	~5	₹1.25
Admin notifications (utility)	~30	₹9
GRAND TOTAL	~9,335	₹3,159/month

With Smart Sending Optimization

Optimization	Savings
Free-form within service window (order confirmations)	-₹420
Admin free-form after reply (daily)	-₹591
Batch utility templates same day	-₹150
Optimized Total	~₹2,000-2,500/month

6. Smart Sending Strategy

Decision Logic (Implemented in Code)

```
WHEN sending a notification to customer/admin:

1. CHECK: Is there an active SERVICE window?
  └ YES → Send FREE-FORM text/buttons/lists (₹0 FREE)
  └ NO  → 2. CHECK: Is there an active UTILITY window?
            └ YES → Send utility template (₹0 FREE, same window)
            └ NO  → Send utility template (₹0.30, opens new window)
```

Implementation in Platform

The `MessageOrchestratorService.sendSmartMessage()` method handles this automatically:

```
// Automatically chooses cheapest delivery method:
await orchestrator.sendSmartMessage(
  tenantId, phoneNumberId, accessToken, customerPhone,
  "Your order #ORD-042 is confirmed! 3 items, Rs. 1,299", // Free-form (if window open)
  { name: 'order_confirmation', language: 'en', components: [...] } // Template (if no window)
);
```

Admin Notification Strategy

```
DAILY ADMIN FLOW:

9:00 AM - First order of the day
```

No service window → Send template (₹0.30)
9:01 AM – Admin sees notification, replies "CONFIRM"
→ Service window opens!
9:15 AM – Second order → Free-form + buttons (₹0)
10:00 AM – Payment received → Free-form + buttons (₹0)
11:30 AM – Low stock alert → Free-form + button (₹0)
2:00 PM – Another order → Free-form + buttons (₹0)
5:00 PM – Daily summary → Free-form + button (₹0)
TOTAL COST FOR THE DAY: ₹0.30 (just one template!)

Tips to Maximize Free Messaging

Tip	How It Saves
Reply to customer within their service window	All replies FREE
Use free-form text for order confirmations	Saves ₹0.30/order when customer just chatted
Encourage admin to reply to first notification	Opens free service window for entire day
Batch shipping + delivery notifications same day	Share one utility window (₹0.30 instead of ₹0.60)
Use interactive buttons in service window	Rich UX for FREE (vs. template with buttons costs ₹0.30)

7. Subscription Plans & Pricing

Platform Operating Costs (Per Tenant)

Cost Item	Monthly (INR)
Server/DB/Redis (shared)	₹200-500
WhatsApp API costs (passed through)	Varies by usage
Maintenance & support	₹200
Base platform cost	₹400-700

Recommended Plans

Starter Plan — ₹1,499/month

Feature	Limit
Customers	200
Orders/month	500
Conversations (utility + marketing)	1,000
Campaigns/month	2
Workflow builder	Basic (5 workflows)
Admin WhatsApp notifications	Included
Overage rate	₹0.50/conversation

Your cost: ~₹600 | Your profit: ~₹900 (60%)

Growth Plan — ₹3,499/month

Feature	Limit
Customers	1,000
Orders/month	2,000
Conversations (utility + marketing)	5,000
Campaigns/month	5
Workflow builder	Advanced (20 workflows)
Admin WhatsApp notifications	Included
Analytics dashboard	Included
Overage rate	₹0.40/conversation

Your cost: ~₹2,000 | Your profit: ~₹1,500 (43%)

Pro Plan — ₹6,999/month

Feature	Limit
Customers	5,000
Orders/month	10,000
Conversations (utility + marketing)	20,000
Campaigns/month	15
Workflow builder	Unlimited
Admin WhatsApp notifications	Included
AI features	Included
Multi-user access	5 users
Overage rate	₹0.35/conversation

Your cost: ~₹5,500 | Your profit: ~₹1,500 (21%)

Enterprise Plan — ₹14,999/month

Feature	Limit
Customers	Unlimited
Orders/month	Unlimited
Conversations	50,000
Campaigns/month	Unlimited
Workflow builder	Unlimited
All features	Included

Dedicated support	Priority
Custom integrations	Available
Overage rate	₹0.30/conversation

Your cost: ~₹10,000 | **Your profit:** ~₹5,000 (33%)

Free Trial — 14 Days

Feature	Limit
Customers	20
Orders	50
Conversations	100
Campaigns	1

Your max cost: ~₹50 per trial user

Profit Margin Analysis

Plan	Revenue	Your Cost	Profit	Margin
Starter	₹1,499	₹600	₹899	60%
Growth	₹3,499	₹2,000	₹1,499	43%
Pro	₹6,999	₹5,500	₹1,499	21%
Enterprise	₹14,999	₹10,000	₹4,999	33%

Revenue Projections (50 Tenants)

Mix	Tenants	Monthly Revenue	Monthly Cost	Monthly Profit
25 Starter	25	₹37,475	₹15,000	₹22,475
15 Growth	15	₹52,485	₹30,000	₹22,485
8 Pro	8	₹55,992	₹44,000	₹11,992
2 Enterprise	2	₹29,998	₹20,000	₹9,998
TOTAL	50	₹1,75,950	₹1,09,000	₹66,950

8. Template Compliance Rules

What Meta Checks

Rule	Violation Consequence
Utility must reference specific transaction	Template rejected
Marketing must have unsubscribe option	Template rejected
Auth must contain ONLY the OTP	Template rejected

No misleading category (promo as utility)	Template reclassified + possible ban
Must match declared category	Auto-reclassification
Repeated violations	Messaging limits reduced
Severe violations	Account restricted/banned

Category Enforcement

CAN YOU SEND PROMO CONTENT AS UTILITY?

- ❌ NO – Meta will:
1. Reject the template during review
 2. Or reclassify it to Marketing (you pay ₹0.80 instead of ₹0.30)
 3. Or ban the template after reports
 4. Or reduce your messaging tier

WHAT YOU CAN DO INSTEAD:

- ✅ Send promos as FREE-FORM within a service window (₹0 – totally legal)
- ✅ Use marketing templates honestly (₹0.80 – proper channel)

Messaging Tier Limits

Meta assigns quality tiers based on your behavior:

Tier	Daily Message Limit	How to Reach
Unverified	250 unique customers/day	New accounts
Tier 1	1,000 unique customers/day	Verify business
Tier 2	10,000 unique customers/day	Good quality + volume
Tier 3	100,000 unique customers/day	Sustained good quality
Unlimited	No limit	Excellent quality rating

Quality is affected by:

- Customer blocks/reports
- Template rejection rate
- Spam complaints

9. Quick Reference Tables

Decision Matrix — What to Send When

Situation	Send What	Cost
Customer just messaged (within 24h)	Free-form text / buttons / lists	₹0
Customer messaged, you want to confirm order	Free-form "Order confirmed!"	₹0
No service window, need to notify	Utility template	₹0.30
Already sent utility template today	Another utility template	₹0

Want to send campaign to inactive users	Marketing template	₹0.80
Need to verify phone number	Auth template	₹0.25
Admin hasn't messaged today, new order	Utility template to admin	₹0.30
Admin replied earlier today	Free-form + buttons to admin	₹0

Message Type vs. Window Compatibility

Message Type	Service Window	Utility Window	Marketing Window	Auth Window	No Window
Free-form text	✅ FREE	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails
Interactive buttons	✅ FREE	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails
Interactive lists	✅ FREE	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails
Images/Videos	✅ FREE	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails	❌ Fails
Utility template	✅ * (₹0.30)	✅ FREE	❌ (₹0.30)	❌ (₹0.30)	✅ (₹0.30)
Marketing template	✅ * (₹0.80)	❌ (₹0.80)	✅ FREE	❌ (₹0.80)	✅ (₹0.80)
Auth template	✅ * (₹0.25)	❌ (₹0.25)	❌ (₹0.25)	✅ FREE	✅ (₹0.25)

*Templates ALWAYS charge for their own category, even within a service window.

Monthly Cost by Business Size

Business Size	Customers	Orders/mo	Smart Cost	Without Optimization
Micro	100	200	₹200-400	₹600
Small	500	1,000	₹800-1,200	₹2,000
Medium	1,000	2,000	₹1,500-2,500	₹3,200
Large	5,000	10,000	₹6,000-9,000	₹15,000
Enterprise	10,000+	20,000+	₹12,000-18,000	₹30,000+

Summary

1. **Service window (customer messages first) = FREE** — send anything
2. **Templates ALWAYS open their own paid window** — even within service window
3. **Smart strategy:** Free-form within service window, templates only when necessary
4. **Admin notifications:** First one costs ₹0.30/day, rest are free after admin replies
5. **Never disguise marketing as utility** — Meta will catch it
6. **Subscription pricing:** Cover WhatsApp costs + infrastructure + 40-60% margin